

Object 1: Adult Gas Mask

Play the video, encouraging students to look carefully at the object, then reveal the first investigation question.

Question 1: Do you know what this object is?

- Some students are likely to recognise this as a gas mask.
- If students are not sure, prompt them to think about the shape of the object. How do they think this was used?

Answer: This is a gas mask. Gas masks were carried by everybody in Britain during World War Two, to protect people in case Nazi Germany dropped a gas bomb on Britain. This didn't happen, but people were prepared.



Question 2: How do you think gas masks were worn?

- Look at the shapes and details: the window for the eyes, the filter over the nose and mouth.
- Encourage students to look carefully at the gas mask - can they see anything that they didn't spot immediately? They might notice that the size - 'medium' - is written across the top.

Answer: Gas masks were worn on your head, covering your face. The window lets you see, and the filter at the bottom helps you to breathe without letting in the gas. The straps are adjustable, and gas masks came in different sizes - did you spot which size this one is?

Question 3: Gas masks were carried in boxes with string straps. How would you feel if you had to carry this around everywhere you went?

- Students might imagine feeling scared by the idea of an attack. Ask them whether they think that feeling would be there for the whole war, or whether they think they would get used to it quickly.
- Students might think about the inconvenience of having to carry this everywhere - to school, work, even just going to a friend's house.

Answer: At first, you might have been excited, scared, worried or even irritated by carrying your gas mask everywhere you went, but after a few months of war, gas masks were just part of everyday life.

Summary: This type of gas mask was worn by adults and older children. Children aged 2 to 5 were given a different type of gas mask. Have a look at the next object to see what it looked like.

Object 2: Child's Gas Mask

Play the video, encouraging students to look carefully at the object, then reveal the first investigation question.

Question 1: How is this different to the adult gas mask?

Students might notice:

- The gas mask is red rather than black
- The eyes are smaller and circular, instead of a single window
- The gas mask has blue and green accents
- The straps are thinner and lighter

Answer: You probably noticed the brighter colours on the child's mask. The eye sections are a little bit different, and the mask is much smaller than the adult's gas mask. Did you notice any other differences?



Question 2: Why do you think this child's gas mask is different to the adult one?

- Encourage students to think about the differences that they noticed
- Why might those changes have been made?

Answer: Adult gas masks were heavy, so young children needed smaller, lighter gas masks. Gas masks could be scary. Giving colourful gas masks to younger children, like this red 'Mickey Mouse' one, helped to make wearing it a bit more fun.

Question 3: What do you think this gas mask is made from?

Students might mention:

- The rubber body of the mask
- The metal eye sections and filter
- The fabric straps

If students aren't sure, prompt them to look at how the materials move in the video.

- Does it look solid or drapery?
- Does it look like it's heavy or light?

Answer: Adult gas masks were heavy, so young children needed smaller, lighter gas masks. Gas masks could be scary. Giving colourful gas masks to younger children, like this red 'Mickey Mouse' one, helped to make wearing it a bit more fun.

Summary: So everyone in Britain carried a gas mask during World War Two - making those must have used a lot of materials! Let's have a look at our next object and see what we can discover...

Object 3: Clothing Ration Book

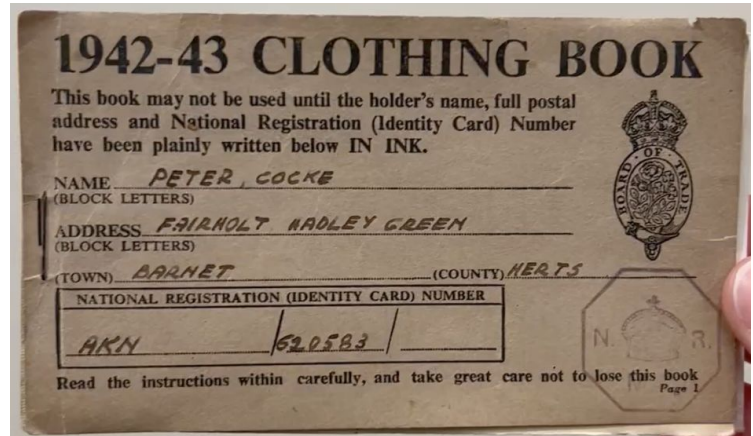
Play the video, encouraging students to look carefully at the object, then reveal the first investigation question.

Question 1: Can you work out what this object is?

This is a clothing ration book.

- Encourage students to look at the words for clues
- Does it look similar to anything they've seen before? If you've already completed Investigation 1, they might spot similarities to the food ration book.

Answer: This is a clothing ration book. It limited how much new clothing people in Britain could buy. Different numbers of points were needed to buy different types of clothes, depending on the amount of material and labour needed to make them.



Question 2: Can you think of anything else that was rationed during World War Two?

- Students may be familiar with the idea of rationing food. If they are, see if they can remember what types of food were rationed.

Answer: Food was also rationed during World War Two. Foods like butter, eggs, sugar, and even sweets and chocolate were limited, and people had a food ration book as well as their clothing ration book.

Question 3: Why do you think clothes were rationed?

- Students will probably suggest that there weren't enough clothes for everybody. Prompt them to think about why that was
- Fabric was being used for uniforms
- Factories were busy producing clothing for the military and uniforms for Home Front volunteers, so they didn't have capacity to make pre-war amounts of clothing.

Answer: Lots of clothes had to be made during the war. Between military uniforms and uniforms worn by volunteers in Britain, about a quarter of the population wore a uniform. Fabric was in short supply, so factories couldn't make as much ordinary clothing and people had to mend their clothes instead of buying new ones.

Summary: With everyone carrying a gas mask, and all of those military uniforms to make, materials were in short supply. Let's look at the next object to find out more...

Object 4: Propaganda Poster

Give students a few seconds to look carefully at the image, then reveal the first investigation question.

Question 1: What can you see in this poster?

Students might notice a variety of things in this poster. As they point them out, encourage them to think about why those things have been included in the poster.

- The red text on the left says 'Each shell contains a 'cup' made of card. 1 soap carton makes 3 25-pounder 'cups'.'
 - Cups were part of the ammunition for the type of gun seen in the poster.
- Students could also think about the colours used in the poster and the impact they have.

Answer: 'Cogs' was the nickname given to the Junior Salvage Stewards. These were children who signed up to collect 'salvage' from local households, which would be taken to be used in factories.

Salvaging means saving something to be used again. During World War Two, certain types of household waste, or salvage, were collected to be reused, just like our recycling is today!

Question 2: Look at the children's expressions. How do you think they feel about being part of the Cogs?

- The children in the poster look happy and excited. Being part of the Cogs was an adventure for many children and they took on the responsibility with excitement.
- There is pride in their expressions too. They are saying 'look what's happening to our salvage', and looking at the gun being fired, using their salvage to make the cartridges.

Answer: Did you notice the children smiling? Maybe you said they look happy, excited or even proud to be Cogs.



Question 3: How does this poster encourage children to join the Cogs?

See if the students can pick out key features:

- The badge reward
- Boys and girls playing their part - getting involved in the war effort
- Smiling children
- Bold colours are inviting and exciting

Answer: This is a propaganda poster created by the British government. Propaganda tries to influence people's beliefs and actions.

This poster presents joining the Cogs as a fun role where children can be part of the war effort, and earn a badge as a reward.

Summary: So children were involved in the war effort in Britain! It looks like the Cogs had a really important job, saving materials to be reused. I wonder what types of materials they salvaged?

Object 5: Shrapnel

Play the video, encouraging students to look carefully at the object, then reveal the first investigation question.



Question 1: What material do you think this is?

Hopefully students will recognise this by the silver colour as metal, and they might also notice that parts of it are shiny.

Answer: This is a piece of metal - a bit of shrapnel which has been flung out during a big explosion. Lots of bombs were dropped on Britain during World War Two, mostly in big cities. This meant that there was a lot of shrapnel, which children used to collect.

Question 2: Metal was one of the materials collected by Cogs. They collected pieces of shrapnel like this, as well as old saucepans and metal railings. What do you think this metal was used for?

Prompt students to think about things used during World War Two which were made of metal.

Answer: Metal was needed to make lots of important machinery during World War Two, including tanks, ships and guns.

Question 3: Can you think of any other ordinary materials that might have been salvaged?

- If students struggle to think of things, prompt them to think about materials that they recycle at school or at home
- Be aware that plastic was not as commonly used and was not salvaged

Answer: Paper was used to make lots of different things, including parts of weapons. Old fabric was turned into uniforms, and food scraps were used to feed farm animals. Rubber was used to make tyres, wellington boots and replacement parts for gas masks.

Summary: Wow, we've found out so much information from these objects! Click on the button below to learn some more about the Women's Land Army.

Once you click the 'Learn More' button, students will be given more information about the Cogs by Grace, the character that they met at the beginning of the session.

After that, use the activity prompt and get your students to write postcards encouraging their friends to join the Cogs. Use the links on the 'Teacher Guide' page of the website to download the template.

Check out the 'adaptations' section of the Teacher Guide page for ideas that could make this session more accessible to a range of students.